

STILL IN COMMAND

Despite the odds being against him, President Musharraf manages to turn the tables on his opponents and stay on top, but he may emerge considerably weakened by the political battle

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THE SURVIVOR:
General Musharraf



**MUSHARRAF DIVIDED
THE OPPOSITION AND
MANIPULATED THE
POLITICAL SYSTEM TO
ENSURE HIS CONTINUITY.**

■ **By Hasan Zaidi in Karachi**

During the 11-year reign of military dictator General Zia-ul-Haq, a wit had dubbed him “Pakistan’s greatest politician”, in deference to his mastery of the rough and tumble of realpolitik. The title consciously eschewed reference to ‘statesmanship’, which Zia projected as his forte. After the events of the last 10 days, General Pervez Musharraf could easily surpass Zia in his claim to the same title.

Not only was Musharraf able to successfully divide an ominous opposition movement against him, he also brought Pakistan Peoples Party (PPP)—ostensibly the largest and most credi-

ble Opposition party—to his side, something Zia had never managed to do.

Although the results of the October 6 presidential elections cannot be officially notified until the Supreme Court delivers its verdict—expected on October 17—on the legitimacy of Musharraf standing for a re-election, most observers believe that the General has sailed past the worst. Given an earlier judgement wherein the Supreme Court had dismissed the petitions against Musharraf as “unmaintainable”—much to the shock of the Opposition—not many expect the apex court to hurl the country in crisis by annulling the President’s re-election. If the comments of the judges on the bench during the hearings are any

indication, the court seems to be weary of politicians who abdicate their responsibilities in Parliament and rely on the court to be their political battering ram. “The superior judiciary, all said and done, is a part of this establishment and state,” says veteran journalist M.B. Naqvi. “The political changes the lawyers and public want require political action by political parties, but that is missing.”

For their part, the stock markets—always a barometer of how businessmen perceive future stability—reacted with jubilation at the news of Musharraf’s victory, rocketing up-